

students. Critics mention that just buying the software for schools will cost Rs 238 crores (a crore is 10 million!). The logical culmination of this—with a computer for each student and teacher—is an potential expenditure of more than Rs 2800 crores in Maharashtra alone. And we haven't even started talking hardware.

This is the taxpayer's money. India can ill afford such profligacy when 80 per cent of its population lives on less than Rs 20 a day and 26 per cent on less than Rs 12 a day.

Home infrastructure

Unless you have your office footing the bill for a proprietary licence for your home PCs or you really like to spend money buying licences, you should have Linux running on at least one of your machines at home, if not all. If you have not sampled the Linux desktop lately, you are missing something. Mint, Ubuntu (with its flavours Kubuntu and Edubuntu), and Mandriva, among many others, offer a great desktop experience. The productivity tools (e-mail, browsers, chat, office suites, etc) have matured from their early days and what's more, they are all based on open standards. They also interface seamlessly with proprietary formats that matter. Linux as the platform of choice opens the door for FOSS-based education tools, though many of the education tools run on Intel platforms, too.

Kindergarten

Junior wants to play Daddy and guess what, he wants his own computer time, too. This is just the right time to introduce some mouse training and maybe the alphabet. The following are some good computer discovery programs.

ChildsPlay (schoolisplay.org) is a program for mouse and keyboard with puzzles, memory games, flash cards and sound.

Gcompris (gcompris.net) is a computer discovery program for 2- to 10-year-olds with over a 100 activities. More seem to be getting added regularly. This program has a long list of testimonials and is also being used for rehabilitation and training of differently-abled people.

PySyCache (pysycache.com) is an amazing theme-able and extensible mouse trainer. Your kids will love its look and feel.

Both KDE (edu.kde.org) and GNOME (live.gnome.org) have their own educational projects. KDE and GNOME are two prominent desktop environments in Linux, among many others.

Klettres helps learn the alphabet and sounds in many languages. It even has Hindi, Kannada and Telugu language packs. Klettres is as helpful for adults learning a new language as it is for kids.

KwordQuiz is a vocabulary building program based on flash cards and multiple choice questions that can be used to administer your own quiz.

Parley is another feature-rich, flash card driven learning program that can be used for vocabulary training or general purpose quiz practice.

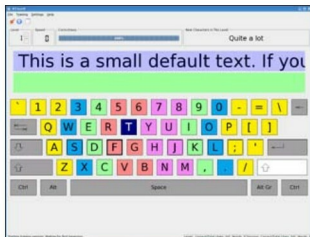


Figure 1: KTouch is a program to learn typing

No Kindergarten software suite is complete without a painting program. **TuxPaint** (tuxpaint.org) is feature packed to keep your tot engaged for hours.

Primary school level

For some advanced vocabulary skills there is **Kanagram**, **KHangMan** and **WordPlay**. Asymptopia (asymptopia.org) has some interesting programs like **TuxWordSmith** and **Crossword Builder** for advanced users.

Now there are math skills to be learned, too. **TuxMathScrabble**, **Multiplication Station**, and **Math Crosswords** (all from Asymptopia) can give the young scholar a run around the block. For exercises in fractions there is **Kbruch**.

This is probably a good time to learn typing, too. Given that much of our time (for the gadget freaks, at least) is going to be spent interacting with a keyboard-based device, a hunt-and-peck approach at the keyboard can be a big productivity drainer. **KTouch** and **Klavar** are typing tutors that help you learn and practice at your own pace, with graded lessons.

Logo is a popular language taught in schools to introduce basic programming concepts while controlling a turtle that leaves a trail as it travels across the screen. **KTurtle** implements the Logo programming language with an uncluttered interface.

OLPC

It gets even better. You have probably heard about the One Laptop per Child (OLPC) project. If not, it is worth a visit to **laptop.org** to learn how bright minds are making learning both child-centric and fun using the best FOSS technology on offer today. The OLPC runs a modified version of Fedora, but the attention grabber, or shall we say game changer, is the Sugar desktop.

Sugar is a desktop that articulates a child's world view and has a bunch of activities with learning objectives. They are: word processing, music, calculator, chat, memory games, Logo, and many more applications—all whittled down to a complexity level that is age appropriate. This makes Sugar the ideal one-stop, but with a gentle